

The Maximal Facts Resurrection Argument

A Formal Reconstruction of Lydia McGrew's 'Maximal Data' Approach

Abstract: This handout presents Lydia McGrew’s formal argument for the resurrection of Jesus Christ using a maximal evidential framework. Contrary to the 'Minimal Facts' approach popularized by Gary Habermas and Michael Licona, McGrew's 'Maximal Data' argument integrates all historically defensible evidence from the canonical Gospels, Acts, and Pauline corpus. Her approach rests on the cumulative case method, source reliability, and inference to the best explanation.

I. Methodological Framework

McGrew’s methodology emphasizes epistemic responsibility toward the available data rather than consensus-based limitation. She argues that Christian apologists should employ the full evidential record when constructing a case for the resurrection. This framework is defined by three principles:

- 1. Historical Data Principle:** All well-attested data—whether or not universally conceded—should be utilized.
- 2. Source Reliability Principle:** The canonical Gospels are prima facie historically reliable documents, grounded in eyewitness or close secondhand testimony.
- 3. Cumulative Case Principle:** Historical reasoning must proceed from multiple, converging lines of evidence that mutually reinforce each other.

II. Comparative Framework: Minimal vs. Maximal Data

	Minimal Facts (Habermas/Licona)	Maximal Data (Lydia McGrew)
Epistemic Basis	Restricts data to facts broadly accepted by critical scholarship.	Admits all historically defensible data regardless of skeptical concession.
Primary Sources	Pauline epistles and early creedal material (1 Cor. 15:3–5).	Full canonical corpus: Gospels, Acts, Pauline and Petrine testimony.
Goal	Demonstrate that the resurrection hypothesis is plausible given minimal concessions.	Demonstrate that the resurrection is the most probable explanation of the full evidential record.
Outcome	Affirms that 'something happened' to cause early Christian belief.	Concludes that Jesus of Nazareth was bodily raised from the dead.

III. Core Historical Data (The 'Maximal Facts')

1. Jesus' Death by Crucifixion	Multiple attestation from independent Christian and non-Christian sources (Tacitus, Josephus).
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2. Burial in a Known Tomb	Joseph of Arimathea's tomb; unlikely to be fictional due to early tradition and public verifiability.
3. Empty Tomb	Attested in all four Gospels, discovered by women—an 'embarrassing witness' criterion of authenticity.
4. Post-Resurrection Appearances	Physical, extended, and multi-sensory encounters to individuals and groups (Luke 24, John 20–21, Acts 1).
5. Transformation of the Disciples	Psychological and behavioral transformation from fear to proclamation under persecution.
6. Early Proclamation	The resurrection message arose within months of the crucifixion, not decades (1 Cor. 15:3–8).
7. Conversion of Skeptics	Hostile witnesses such as Saul of Tarsus and James converted after claimed post-mortem experiences.
8. Reliability of Sources	Confirmed through undesigned coincidences, intertextual coherence, and early eyewitness framework.

IV. Logical Structure of the Argument

Premise 1: The cumulative historical data (crucifixion, burial, empty tomb, and post-mortem appearances) are well-attested by reliable sources.

Premise 2: Competing naturalistic hypotheses (hallucination, conspiracy, legend, swoon, wrong tomb) fail to account for the full evidential scope.

Premise 3: The resurrection hypothesis offers superior explanatory scope, coherence, and plausibility.

Conclusion: Therefore, the bodily resurrection of Jesus is the most reasonable historical explanation.

V. Assessment of Alternative Hypotheses

Alternative Hypothesis	McGrew's Critique
Hallucination Theory	Fails to explain collective experiences and physical interactions (Luke 24:39–43).
Conspiracy Theory	Psychologically implausible; disciples had no motive for deliberate deception.
Legendary Development	Resurrection proclamation is too early; eyewitness control would prevent mythic growth.
Swoon or Apparent Death	Roman crucifixion ensured death; medical recovery impossible in time frame presented.
Wrong Tomb	Public burial site known to both followers and enemies; empty tomb would be easily refuted.

VI. Philosophical and Epistemological Notes

McGrew's argument functions as an instance of inference to the best explanation (IBE). She and Tim McGrew advocate a Bayesian cumulative case methodology wherein the resurrection hypothesis maximizes explanatory power and coherence given the background evidence. This approach does not presuppose theological commitments but argues inductively from historical probability.

VII. Conclusion

The 'Maximal Data' approach, by integrating the full evidential record, produces a more comprehensive and epistemically robust argument for the resurrection than minimalist frameworks. While it demands greater historical and textual defense, its explanatory success renders it the superior model for scholarly apologetics.

Key References

- Lydia McGrew, *Hidden in Plain View: Undesigned Coincidences in the Gospels and Acts* (2017).
- Lydia McGrew, *The Mirror or the Mask: Liberating the Gospels from Literary Devices* (2019).

- Timothy & Lydia McGrew, "The Argument from Miracles," in *The Blackwell Companion to Natural Theology* (2011).
- Gary Habermas & Michael Licona, *The Case for the Resurrection of Jesus* (2004, for contrast).